

No Genuine Copula in Japanese: a reanalysis of 'da' as a conceptual-locative postposition plus a one-argument existential verb¹

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Abstract

This paper proposes a new analysis of the Japanese so-called copula *da* and its non-contracted form *dearu*. Traditionally, *da/dearu* has been regarded as a single copular verb equivalent to English *to be*. However, the morphosyntactic and prosodic separability between *de* and *aru* in *dearu*, along with the syntactic and prosodic constituency of NPs and *de*, show that this interpretation appears inadequate. Instead, we propose that *da/dearu* should be reanalysed as **the conceptual-locative postposition *de* combined with the one-argument existential verb *aru***.

Under this analysis, *A=wa B dearu* 'A is B' is syntactically an **existence-asserting and domain-specifying** sentence. It consists of the **ONE-ARGUMENT core phrase** [*A=wa aru*] 'A exists' and the **ADJUNCT** [*B=de*] 'in the conceptual domain of B' or, more simply, 'as B'. Schematically, this can be represented as the **conjunctive proposition** $\text{EXIST}(A) \wedge \text{IN}(A, B)$ — distinct from the simple $\text{BE}(A, B)$ encoded by *to be*. The syntactically adjunctive *B=de* is non-deletable due to its pragmatic and informational indispensability, as it functions as the **focus of the sentence**, whereas the syntactically obligatory *kare=wa aru* represents the **presupposition/background**.

This study then considers the historical development of this construction together with another related one, which originally shared the same form: *A B=ni ari*. The diachronic split:

- $A B=\textit{ni ari} \rightarrow A B=\textit{nite ari} \rightarrow A=\textit{wa B=de aru}$ — $\text{E}(A) \wedge \text{IN}(A, B)$
- $A B=\textit{ni ari} \rightarrow A B=\textit{ni ari} \rightarrow A=\textit{wa B=ni aru/iru}$ — $\text{IN}(A, B)$

may reflect a shift from a stage in which *=ni* marked both arguments and adjuncts to one in which *=ni* and *=nite* — later, *=de* — became specialized as argumental and adjunctive markers, respectively.

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This analysis also accounts for the default negation pattern of $A=wa\ B=de\ aru \rightarrow E(A) \wedge IN(A, B)$ — which is the **partial negation** $A=wa\ B=de=wa\ nai \rightarrow E(A) \wedge \neg IN(A, B)$ — rather than the total negation $A=wa\ B=de\ nai \rightarrow \neg(E(A) \wedge IN(A, B))$ — showing that the negator applies only to the adjunct domain $B=de \rightarrow IN(A, B)$ — rather than to the existence of A itself — $E(B)$. This reanalysis thus provides a unified account of the structure, semantics and historical development of Japanese *da/dearu* constructions.

1. Introduction — morphosyntactic and prosodic separability between *de* and *aru* in *dearu* and syntactic and prosodic constituency of NPs plus *de*

In Japanese linguistics, *da* and *dearu* have traditionally been treated as a copula equivalent to *to be* in English, as in (1), where *dearu* can be replaced by *=da*, '=' indicating enclisis:

- (1) kare=wa gakusei dearu
 he(SUBJ)=TOP student(PRED) COP
 'He is a student.'

However, this analysis faces a major challenge: it cannot account for the **high degree of independence between *de* and *aru* in *dearu***. For example, when the noun *gakusei* 'student' is marked by the focus/additive particle *=mo* 'also' — one of the so-called *toritatesi* in Japanese — the sentence cannot take the form shown in (2):

- (2) *kare=wa gakusei =mo **dearu**
 he(SUBJ)=TOP student(PRED) also(ADD) COP
 'He is also a student.'

but must be as in (3):

- (3) kare=wa gakusei **de** =mo **aru**
 he(SUBJ)=TOP student(PRED) COP? also(ADD) COP?
 'He is also a student.'

The particle *=mo* is inserted between *de* and *aru*, as if it were an infix — a situation comparable to the adverb *also* being inserted into the copula *is* in English. Furthermore, in (4):

- (4) kare=wa gakusei **deari** kanozyo=wa syakaizin **=da**
 he(SUBJ)=TOP student(PRED) COP she(SUBJ)=TOP working adult(PRED) COP
 'He is a student, she is a working adult.'

the first *deari* may be reduced to *de* alone, without *ari*, as in (5):

- (5) kare=wa gakusei **de** kanozyo=wa syakaizin **=da**
 he(SUBJ)=TOP student(PRED) COP? she(SUBJ)=TOP working adult(PRED) COP
 'He is a student, she is a working adult.'

Furthermore, prosodically, the so-called copula *dearu* exhibits unexpected behaviour. If *dearu* were a single word, the utterance *kare=wa gakusei dearu* would be prosodised as either (6) or

(7), where " | " marks a prosodic-word boundary, and prosodic words in Japanese generally correspond to traditional *bunsetsu*:

(6) | *kare=wa* | *gakusei=dearu* | — *dearu* as an enclitic (i.e. encliticised to *gakusei*)

(7) | *kare=wa* | *gakusei* | ***dearu*** | — *dearu* as an independent prosodic word (ω)

In actual speech, nevertheless, the prosodisation is implemented as in (8):

(8) | *kare=wa* | *gakusei=de* | ***aru*** | — *de* as an enclitic and *aru* as an independent ω

Since prosodic-word boundaries are determined with reference to morphosyntactic information (Nespor & Vogel 2007), the fact that the utterance is prosodised as | *kare=wa* | *gakusei=de* | *aru* | strongly suggests the presence of a morphosyntactic boundary between *de* and *aru* — namely, that *de* and *aru* constitute distinct morphosyntactic elements. This prosodic separation is further supported by the fact that the discourse particle *=ne* can intervene between *de* and *aru* (cf. the discourse particle *=ne* insertion test), which would be impossible if *dearu* constituted a single prosodic word.

All of these facts show that ***de* and *aru* are morphosyntactically and prosodically separable**, whereas **the NP *gakusei* and *de* are always syntactically and prosodically inseparable**, as indicated in (9):

(9) *Kare=wa gakusei de aru.*

Kare=wa gakusei de mo aru.

Kare=wa gakusei de, kanozyo=wa syakaizin=da.

Hence, in *kare=wa gakusei dearu*, the sequence *gakusei* plus *de* is assumed to constitute a single inseparable constituent, as Dalla Chiesa (2015) notes: "the NP-*de* element must always be the phrase (in the closest proximity to the verb)"², where the parenthetical remark is by the

² She argues that the ungrammaticality of **neko=de wagahai=ga aru* 'I am a cat' supports her claim that "the NP-*de* element must always be the phrase in the closest proximity to the verb". However, the ungrammaticality of this sentence does not arise from word order, but rather from the fact that *wagahai*, while functioning as a topic, is not marked by *=wa*. Indeed, although rather awkward, *neko=de*

present author. This *gakusei de* is formally identical to a **postpositional phrase (PP) consisting of a NP + the postposition =de**. In what follows, therefore, *gakusei de* will be treated as a PP, that is, PP *gakusei=de*. This separation between *=de* and *aru* is compatible with Matsuoka's observation that "the copula *da* consists of the postposition *de* and the verb *aru*" (2019: 142). The fact that *gakusei=de* and *aru* each form separate prosodic words can thus be naturally accounted for.

2. NP + =de as a conceptual-locative adjunct PP and the one-argument existential verb *aru*

In Japanese, **postpositional phrases (PPs) of the form [NP + =de]** generally function as **adjuncts**. Accordingly, *kare=wa gakusei=de aru* can be syntactically analysed as consisting of the **obligatory structure [kare=wa aru]** and the **adjunct structure [gakusei=de]**. Further justification for treating *gakusei=de* not as an argument but rather as an adjunct will be provided in Section 7.

In *kare=wa aru*, the predicate *aru* — or, more precisely, its stem *ar-* — can thus be analysed as a **ONE-ARGUMENT verb**, taking only the NP *kare* as its argument. When the verb *aru* functions as **one-argument predicate**, it means '**to exist**' — though in a rather literary sense — as in *ware omou, yueni ware ari* 'I think, therefore I am', and "**aru**"=*to iu koto=wa dō iu koto=ka=to iu toi* 'the problem of what it means "to exist"'. The sentence *kare=wa aru* can thus be interpreted as 'he exists', **asserting the existence** of *kare*. This meaning is reflected in the everyday compound word *ariyō*, which signifies 'manner of **existing**', derived from the stem *ari-* of the verb *aru* in this sense — namely, 'to exist' — combined with the nominal formative *-yō* 'manner, mode'. Further justification for analysing *aru* in this construction as 'to exist' — a meaning that, for pragmatic and informational reasons, is rarely brought to the speaker's or hearer's awareness in ordinary identificational contexts of the type 'A = B' — will be presented in Section 5.

As for the PP *gakusei=de*, on the other hand, although **postpositional phrases headed by =de** can express a variety of semantic roles such as location, means or cause, in this case it can be interpreted as neither means nor cause. The most plausible interpretation is thus **locative** —

wagahai=wa aru is not completely ungrammatical, and expressions such as NP=*de* *watasi=wa ari-tai* 'as the referent denoted by the NP I want to exist' — e.g. *ryōsikitekina syakaizin=de watasi=wa ari-tai* 'as a rational member of society I want to exist' — sound much more natural.

though not a physical, but a **conceptual, location**. Consequently, *gakusei=de* means 'in the conceptual domain of "student"' or, more simply, 'as a student'.

The entire structure *kare=wa gakusei=de aru* is thus, syntactically, composed of the **obligatory ONE-ARGUMENT clause** [*kare wa aru*] 'he exists' and the **ADJUNCT** [*gakusei=de*] 'in the conceptual domain of "student"' or 'as a student'. Semantically, it expresses 'He exists, and his existence is in the conceptual domain of "student"' or, more simply, 'He exists, and it is as a student'. Schematically, $A=wa\ B=de\ aru$ — in which $A=wa\ aru$, even without $B=de$, constitutes a proposition, since $B=de$ is adjunctive — can be represented as $E(A) \wedge IN(A, B)$, where $E(A)$ 'A exists' denotes **the assertion of existence**, and $IN(A, B)$ 'A is in B' denotes **the specification of the domain of existence**. $E(A) \wedge IN(A, B)$ thus constitutes a **conjunctive proposition**.

By contrast, the semantically related and syntactically similar construction $A=wa\ B=ni\ aru/iru$ 'A is in B' — in which $A=wa\ aru/iru$, without $B=ni$, cannot constitute a proposition, since $B=ni$ is argumentative, as discussed in Section 3 — can be represented as $IN(A, B)$ 'A is in B', which denotes the **specification of the domain of location**. $IN(A, B)$ thus constitutes a **simple proposition**. The compositional difference between the conjunctive $E(A) \wedge IN(A, B)$ and the simple $IN(A, B)$ is reflected in their default negation patterns, such as the partial negation $A=wa\ B=de=wa\ nai$ vs. the total negation $A=wa\ B=ni\ nai/i-nai$, which will be discussed in Section 7.

Thus, instead of the traditional **copula-based** analysis in (10) = (1), representable as $BE(A, B)$:

- (10) *kare=wa* *gakusei* **dear-u**
 he(SUBJ)=TOP student(PRED) COP-PRES
 'He is a student.'

in this paper, a **conceptual-locative-postposition-plus-one-argument-existential-verb-based** analysis in (11), representable as $E(A) \wedge IN(A, B)$, is adopted, where CONCEPT-LOC abbreviates 'conceptual-locative':

- (11) *kare=wa* *gakusei=de* **ar-u**
 he(SUBJ)=TOP student=CONCEPT-LOC(ADJUNCT) exist-PRES
 'He exists, and his existence is in the conceptual domain of "student".'

3. The differences between *sore wa gakkō=DE ARu* and *sore wa gakkō=NI ARu*

In contrast to the construction *sore=wa gakkō=de aru* in (12), hypothesised as **existence-**

asserting and domain-specifying in Section 2:

- (12) sore=*wa* gakkō=**de** **ar-u**
it(SUBJ)=TOP school=CONCEP-LOC(ADJUNCT) **exist-PRES**
'It exists, and its existence is in the conceptual domain of "school".'

in genuine locative — namely, **location-specifying-only** — constructions as in (13) and (14), where PHYSIC-LOC abbreviates 'physical-locative':

- (13) sore=*wa* gakkō=**ni** **ar-u**
it(SUBJ)=TOP school=PHYSIC-LOC(ARGUMENT) **be located-PRES**
'It is in the school.'

- (14) kare=*wa* gakkō=**ni** **i-ru**
he(SUBJ)=TOP school=PHYSIC-LOC(ARGUMENT) **be located-PRES**
'He is in the school.'

the **physical-locative argument is obligatory**, as mentioned in Section 2, **and always marked by the postposition =*ni***, rather than =*de*. Thus, the verb *aru* — more precisely, its stem *ar-* — when used as a **LOCATIVE verb**, is a **TWO-ARGUMENT predicate with the argument structure [location, theme]**, the location being denoted by the postpositional phrase [NP + =*ni*], as in *sore=wa gakkō=ni aru*. When the theme is animate, the verb *iru* with the stem *i-* is used instead as in (14), with the **argument PP [NP + =*ni*] unchanged**, as in *kare=wa gakkō=ni iru* 'he is in the school'. By contrast, the sequence of words in (15), in which the argumentative PP [NP + =*ni*] in (14) has been replaced by the PP [NP + =*de*]:

- (15) kare=*wa* gakkō=**de** **i-ru**
he(SUBJ)=TOP school=LOC(ADJUNCT) ?-PRES
'?'

is semantically uninterpretable — even for native speakers — and ungrammatical, suggesting that the PP [NP + =*de*] is adjunctive.

Accordingly, *kare=wa gakusei=de aru* may reasonably be regarded SYNTACTICALLY — though NOT PRAGMATICALLY OR INFORMATIONALLY, as will be discussed in Section 4 — as a **structurally self-contained existence-asserting construction** *kare=wa aru* 'he exists', accompanied by the conceptual-locative adjunct *gakusei=de*, which specifies the domain of existence.

4. The syntactic optionality and pragmatic necessity of *gakusei=de*

Although *gakusei=de* in *kare=wa gakusei=de aru* is **syntactically an adjunct**, it **cannot be deleted**. This is because the sentence, while structurally consisting of the obligatory core *kare=wa aru* 'he exists' and the adjunct *gakusei=de* 'in the conceptual domain of "student"' or 'as a student', serves as a **identificational sentence** in which **the focus is on the adjunct *gakusei=de***.

Therefore, the **non-deletability of *gakusei=de*** arises from its **pragmatic and informational indispensability** rather than from syntactic necessity. The distinction can be represented as follows:

Level	Structure	Function
Syntax	[NP <i>A ar-</i>] + [PP <i>B=de</i>]	One-argument predicate + adjunct
Semantics	"A exists, and it is in the domain B"	Existence assertion + domain specification $E(A) \wedge IN(A, B)$
Information Structure	[<i>A=wa aru</i>] + [<i>B=de</i>]	Given + New (default)
Pragmatics	Focus on <i>B=de</i> (default)	Pragmatic obligatoriness and non-deletability of <i>B=de</i> due to focus

5. Shift of focus and foregrounding of the lexical meaning 'to exist' of the verb *aru*

In the construction *watasi=wa ryōsikitekina syakaizin=de aru* in (16):

- (16) *watasi=wa ryōsikitekina syakaizin=de ar-u*
 I(SUBJ)=TOP rational member of society=CONCEP-LOC(ADJUNCT) **exist-PRES**
 'I EXIST as a rational member of society.'

which can be schematically represented as $E(A) \wedge IN(A, B)$, the existence-asserting component $E(A)$ — that is, the assertion of the lexical meaning 'to exist' encoded in the verbal stem *ar-* — is backgrounded as given information, while the domain-specifying component $IN(A, B)$ is foregrounded as the focus of the utterance. As a result, the meaning 'to exist' is rarely brought to the speaker's or hearer's awareness in ordinary identificational contexts.

By contrast, in example (17), which takes the form **A WANT** [$E(A) \wedge IN(A, B)$], the situation is rather different:

6. From Old Japanese to Contemporary Japanese forms

In Old Japanese (OJ, 700–800), the modern formally distinct constructions $A=wa\ B=de\ aru$ 'A exists (and it is) as B' and $A=wa\ B=ni\ aru/iru$ 'A is (located) in B' would have corresponded to the seemingly identical construction $A\ B=ni\ ari$. "Dative *ni* is the general oblique case, marking both argument and non-argument oblique nominals" (Frellesvig 2010: 126), unlike in Contemporary Japanese, where $=ni$ marks arguments, while $=de$ — which originated from the postposition-suffix sequence $=nite$ — marks adjuncts, in accordance with the diachronic description "OJ *ni* and *nite* became more specialized with *ni* being used more for arguments and *nite* more for adjuncts; from mid to late EMJ *nite* acquired the variant *de* which is still in use in contemporary NJ" (*ibid.*: 243), where EMJ and NJ abbreviate Early Middle Japanese (800–1200) and 'new Japanese' — namely, Modern Japanese, 1600 – — respectively.

Thus, the former $A\ B=ni\ ari$ 'A exists as B' can be analysed as an existence-asserting and domain-specifying construction consisting of the obligatory construction $A\ ari$ 'A exists' — with the verb *ari* being used as **one-argument existential** predicate — and the conceptual-locative adjunct $B=ni$ 'in the conceptual domain referred to by B', as shown in (21). The latter $A\ B=ni\ ari$ 'A is in B', on the other hand, can be analysed as a location-specifying construction — in which *ari* is employed as a **two-argument locative** predicate — and $B=ni$ 'in B' constitutes the physical-locative argument, as indicated in (22), which is consistent with the present analysis:

- (21) A B=**ni** **ari-0**
 A(SUBJ)=TOP B=CONCEP-LOC(ADJUNCT) **exist-PRES**
 'A exists, and it is as B.'
- (22) A B=**ni** **ari-0**
 A(SUBJ)=TOP B=PHYSIC-LOC(ARGUMENT) **be located-PRES**
 'A is in B.'

These superficially identical Old Japanese constructions in (21) and (22), however, diverged into the formally distinct modern constructions in (23) and (24):

- (23) A=wa B=**de** **ar-u**
 A(SUBJ)=TOP B=CONCEP-LOC(ADJUNCT) **exist-PRES**
 'A exists, and it is as B.'
- (24) A=wa B=**ni** **ar-u / i-ru**
 A(SUBJ)=TOP B=PHYSIC-LOC(ARGUMENT) **be located-PRES**
 'A is in B.'

In (24), the locative verbs *aru* and *iru*, both semantically corresponding to the Old Japanese *ari* — though the latter originally derived from another verb *wiru* 'to sit; to be seated' — are used for inanimate and animate entities, respectively. The historical development from (21) to (23) is as follows. In Old Japanese, there existed "analytic forms consisting of an infinitive (*ni* ...) followed by *ar-*" (Frellesvig 2010: 95) for the so-called copula — that is, *ni ar-*. In the subsequent Early Middle Japanese (EMJ, 800–1200) period, this analytic form "*ni ar-* had the variant *nite ar-*" (ibid.: 235). "In the course of EMJ" (ibid.: 235), or more specifically "from the end of the period" (ibid.: 233), "*nite ar-* became *de ar-*" (ibid.: 235). As shown in "Table 12.8. *Development of the copula and adjectival-copula paradigms*" (ibid.: 344), from the end of EMJ to early Late Middle Japanese (early LMJ, Kamakura period 1185-1333), the three forms *ni ar-*, *nite ar-* and *de ar-* coexisted, although "already from late EMJ" (Insei period, 1086-1185), "*ni* was getting more restricted" and "*de* was used far more widely" than *nite*. The same table (ibid.: 344) shows that only the newest *de ar-* continued to be used from late LMJ (Muromachi period 1333-1573) into Contemporary Japanese.

The historical developments in (25) and (26):

$$(25) A B=\textit{ni ari} \rightarrow A B=\textit{nite ari} \quad \rightarrow A=\textit{wa B=de aru} \quad \text{--- } E(A) \wedge \text{IN}(A, B)$$

$$(26) A B=\textit{ni ari} \rightarrow A B=\textit{ni ari} \quad \rightarrow A=\textit{wa B=ni aru/iru} \quad \text{--- } \text{IN}(A, B)$$

may reflect the diachronic split between *=ni*, used for arguments, and *=nite* — later, *=de* — used for adjuncts. This suggests a shift from a linguistic stage in which *=ni* marked both arguments and adjuncts to one in which *=ni* and *=nite/=de* became specialised as argumental and adjunctive markers, respectively. Thus, the historical split of the Old Japanese *=ni ari* between the Modern Japanese *=de aru* and *=ni aru/iru* may not reflect a reanalysis of a single construction, but rather the formal divergence of two distinct semantic structures — 'existence and its location in a conceptual domain' vs. 'location in a physical domain' — that happened to share the same surface form *A B=ni ari* in Old Japanese — a possibility that merits further historical investigation.

7. Default partial negation and the scope of negation marked by the particle *=wa*

The default negation pattern of the existence-asserting and domain-specifying (27) = (11):

- (27) kare=wa gakusei=de ar-u
 he(SUBJ)=TOP student=CONCEP-LOC(ADJUNCT) exist-PRES
 'He exists, and it is as a student.'

which, in line with Section 2, can be schematically represented as the conjunctive $E(A) \wedge IN(A, B)$, is the **partial negation** shown in (28):

- (28) kare=wa gakusei=de=**wa** (*ara-) **-nai-0**
 he(SUBJ)=TOP student=CONCEP-LOC(ADJUNCT)=**SCOPE OF NEG** exist **NEG-PRES**
 'He exists, but it is not as a student.'

rather than the total negation in (29):

- (29) kare=wa gakusei=de (*ara-) **-nai-0**
 he(SUBJ)=TOP student=CONCEP-LOC(ADJUNCT) exist **NEG-PRES**
 'He does not exists as a student.'

(In (28) and (29), the stem of the existential verb *aru* is represented as (*ara-), since in contemporary Standard Japanese the negative form of this verb is not the theoretically expected **ara-nai*, but obligatorily the suppletive adjective *nai*.) The more natural sentence *kare=wa gakusei=de=wa nai* in (28) does **not negate the existence of *kare* itself**, but rather **negates only *gakusei=de* as the domain of existence**. In this way, **the particle =wa in Japanese can mark the scope of negation**.

Schematically, the partial negation $A=wa B=de=wa \text{ nai}$ in (28) — underlyingly, $*A=wa B=de=wa \text{ ara-nai}$ — can be represented as $E(A) \wedge \neg IN(A, B)$, whereas the total negation $A=wa B=de \text{ nai}$ in (29) — underlyingly, $*A=wa B=de \text{ ara-nai}$ — can be represented as $\neg(E(A) \wedge IN(A, B))$, that is, $\neg E(A) \vee \neg IN(A, B)$. Although this disjunction is compatible with $\neg E(A) \wedge IN(A, B)$, $E(A) \wedge \neg IN(A, B)$ or $\neg E(A) \wedge \neg IN(A, B)$, the first case is inconsistent with the semantic postulate $IN(A, B) \Rightarrow E(A)$ — hence $\neg E(A) \Rightarrow \neg IN(A, B)$ — and the third case, $\neg E(A) \wedge \neg IN(A, B) = \neg E(A)$, is pragmatically infelicitous in topicalised clauses with $A=wa$, since $A=wa$, as a topic phrase, tends to presuppose the contextual or situational givenness — that is, the existence — of A , and since there are dedicated Japanese forms for existential negation such as $A=wa \text{ nai/inai}$; in practice, therefore, the interpretation converges on $E(A) \wedge \neg IN(A, B)$. Hence, the former pattern in (28), which unambiguously denotes $E(A) \wedge \neg IN(A, B)$, is judged to be the more natural one.

If $=de \text{ aru}$ were a single copula, then $A=wa B=de \text{ aru}$ would denote $BE(A, B)$, and its negation

would take the form of simple predicate negation — namely, $A=wa\ B=de\ nai$, representable as $\neg BE(A, B)$, with no $=wa$ following $=de$. **Empirically, however, $A=wa\ B=de\ nai$ is perceived as infelicitous, whereas $A=wa\ B=de=wa\ nai$ is preferred.** This spontaneous preference for the particle $=wa$ after $=de$ is unexpected under the simple-copula analysis, but follows naturally if the clause is decomposed as $E(A) \wedge IN(A, B)$, where the logically and pragmatically most plausible interpretation is the partial negation $E(A) \wedge \neg IN(A, B)$.

By contrast, the **default negation of the location-specifying** (30) and (31) = (13) and (14):

(30) $sore=wa$ $gakkō=ni$ $ar-u$
 it(SUBJ)=TOP school=PHYSIC-LOC(ARGUMENT) be located-PRES
 'It is in the school.'

(31) $kare=wa$ $gakkō=ni$ $i-ru$
 he(SUBJ)=TOP school=PHYSIC-LOC(ARGUMENT) be located-PRES
 'He is in the school.'

which can both be represented as $IN(A, B)$, is the **total negation** indicated in (32) and (33):

(32) $sore=wa$ $gakkō=ni$ (* $ara-$) **$nai-0$**
 it(SUBJ)=TOP school=PHYSIC-LOC(ARGUMENT) be located NEG-PRES
 'It is not in the school.'

(33) $kare=wa$ $gakkō=ni$ $i-$ **$nai-0$**
 he(SUBJ)=TOP school=PHYSIC-LOC(ARGUMENT) be located NEG-PRES
 'He is not in the school.'

Unlike the existence-asserting and domain-specifying conjunctive $E(A) \wedge IN(A, B)$, the location-specifying $IN(A, B)$ is a simple proposition and, naturally, its negation constitutes $\neg IN(A, B)$, which corresponds to (32) and (33).

The difference in default negation pattern between the existence-asserting and domain-specifying construction and the purely location-specifying one lies in the fact that the former, **$E(A) \wedge IN(A, B)$, is conjunctive**, whereas the latter, **$IN(A, B)$, is simplex**. This ultimately derives from **the status of B as an adjunct in the former and as an argument in the latter**, since if B were an argument, $E(A) \wedge IN(A, B)$ would correspond to $EXIST-MANNER(A, B)$, whose negation would be the total $\neg EM(A, B)$.

Finally, if $=de\ aru$ were a single copular unit, partial negation with $=wa$ would necessarily take the form $*kare=wa\ \underline{gakusei=wa}\ de\ nai$, as in (34):

- (34) **kare=wa* *gakusei=wa* *de* **nai-0**
 he(SUBJ)=TOP student(PRED)=SCOPE OF NEGATION COP NEG-PRES
 'He is not a student, but something else.'

The fact that this is ungrammatical further supports the separability of *=de* and *aru* and the constituency of *gakusei=de*.

8. The contracted form *=da*

In spoken language, the contracted form *=da* is often used instead of *=de aru*, which is more formal and literal, as in *kare=wa gakusei=da* 'he is a student'. It should be noted that this **contracted form *=da*** does not represent a new copular category but a **purely phonological reduction of the postpositional-verbal complex *=de aru***, as shown in (35):

- (35) *kare=wa* *gakusei=d* **a-0**
 he(SUBJ)=TOP student=CONCEP-LOC(ADJUNCT) **exist-PRES**
 'He exists, and it is as a student.'

The historical change from *=de aru* to *=da*, possibly via *=dea*³, involves no syntactic or semantic reanalysis, but a process of phonetic contraction comparable to French *à le* → *au* 'to the' or Portuguese *de a* → *da* 'from the, of the'. Just as there is no semantic necessity for *à* and *le* to fuse into *au*, or for *de* and *a* into *da* — a phenomenon comparable to the English *to the* or *from the* forming a single word — there is likewise no semantic motivation for *=de* and *aru* to form a single lexical item.

That said, however, the reduction of *aru* to *a* can be accounted for in pragmatic and informational terms. Since the topic phrase *A=wa* generally presupposes the existence of A, and since the occurrence of *B=de* entails the existence of A by virtue of the relation $IN(A, B) \Rightarrow E(A)$, the verb *aru* becomes informationally redundant when it once again refers to A's existence. Furthermore, in a sentence in which $IN(A, B)$ is presented as new information, $E(A)$ is presupposed and thus treated as given, owing to the same entailment $IN(A, B) \Rightarrow E(A)$. In this context, $E(A)$ is pragmatically and informationally less significant than the focus constituent $IN(A, B)$. It may therefore be assumed that **this low pragmatic and informational salience is**

³ Historically, the form *=dea*, which yielded the modern *=da*, can be attested in Azuchi–Momoyama-period materials: *bonnin yorimo giūzaini fuxōzuru cotodea* "(it) is a reason for imposing a heavier guilt (on him) than on an ordinary person" (Amakusa Edition of *Esopo no fabulas*, 1593, p.475, ll.10-11, in Text Data Sets for Research on the History of Japanese).

reflected in the phonological reduction of *aru* to *a*.

The two elements remain distinct in their underlying structure: *=de* functions as a postposition indicating the domain in which existence holds, and the stem of *aru* as the existential verb itself. This is precisely why the following highly colloquial dialogue in (36) is possible:

(36) *Kare=tte gakusei=da yone?* — *Iya, gakusei=tte yū=ka, gakusei=de=mo aru=tte kanzi kana.*

'He's a student, right?' — 'Well, if you can call him a student, I'd say he's *also* a student, kind of.'

In this dialogue, the interlocutor, recognising that the underlying structure of *gakusei=da* is *gakusei=de aru*, when asked to confirm that *kare*'s domain of existence can be identified as that of 'student', replies that his existence extends to other domains as well, expressed by the form *gakusei=de=mo aru*.

Returning to Section 1, *kare=wa gakusei=de, kanozyo=wa syakaizin=da* 'he (is) a student, and she is a working adult' in (5) is thus, underlyingly, a compound sentence *kare=wa gakusei=de ari, kanozyo=wa syakaizin=de aru*, in which the first predicate *ari* constitutes presupposed given information and is therefore judged to be less informationally salient, and consequently deleted as recoverable, based on the structural parallelism between the two coordinate clauses, as indicated in (37):

(37) *kare=wa gakusei=de (ari) kanozyo=wa syakaizin=d a-0*
 he(SUBJ)=TOP student=LOC(ADJC) (exist) she(SUBJ)=TOP working adult=LOC(ADJC) exist-PRES
 'He (exists) as a student, she exists as a working adult.'

(37) is an instance of zeugma, so *=de* is not an inflected form of *=da*. Therefore, *=da* as a whole should not be regarded as a copula in the strict sense, but as a **phonologically reduced surface realisation of the underlying construction *=de aru*** — more theoretically, *=de ar-0*, where *ar-* and *-0* represent the stem of the existential verb *aru* and a phonologically zero tense suffix specified as [–past].

9. Conclusion — *=da* not as a copula but as the conceptual-locative postposition *=de* followed by the one-argument existential verb *aru*

In summary, Japanese has no genuine copula — *da* is not *be*. The construction *A=wa B dearu* 'A

exists, and its domain of existence is B' consists of a **one-argument, existence-asserting core clause** [*A=wa aru*] 'A exists' and a **domain-specifying adjunct** [*B=de*], meaning 'in the conceptual domain denoted by B' or, more simply, 'as B'. It should therefore be syntactically represented as *A=wa B=de aru*. Consequently, treating *dearu* or its contracted form *da* as a single copula is structurally problematic. The form *dearu* is more appropriately analysed as an **existence-domain complex**, consisting of the one-argument existential verb *aru* and the conceptual-locative postposition *=de*, which specifies the domain in which the existence of the theme is realised. The more colloquial form *=da* is simply a phonologically contracted form corresponding to the more formal and literal *=de aru*.

Thus, through the above syntactic analysis, it has been possible to account, by means of a single, consistent principle — namely, the **assertion of existence by** [*NP₁=wa + ar-*] and the **specification of the domain of existence by** [*NP₂ + =de*], schematically representable as **EXIST(NP₁) ∧ IN(NP₁, NP₂), not reducible to BE(A, B)** — for:

- Morphosyntactic separability between *de* and *aru* in *dearu*
- Optional omission of *aru* in *dearu*
- Prosodic-word boundary between *de* and *aru*
- Syntactic and prosodic constituency of NPs plus *de*
- Foregrounding of the lexical meaning 'to exist' of the verb *aru*
- Grounds on which the Japanese *=de ari-tai* is not equivalent to the English *to want to be*
- Diachronic split between *A B=ni ari* → *A B=nite ari* → *A=wa B=de aru* and *A B=ni ari* → *A=wa B=ni aru/iru*
- Grounds on which the default negation of *A=wa B=de aru* is not the total *A=wa B=de nai* but the partial *A=wa B=de=wa nai*
- Underlying structure of *=da* as *=de aru*
- Pragmatic and informational motivation for the phonological reduction *aru* → *a* in *=da*

Finally, whereas the present study reinterprets *=da* and *=de aru* as a postpositional-verbal complex expressing $E(A) \wedge IN(A, B)$ rather than a copular predicate denoting $BE(A, B)$, this reinterpretation does not invalidate previous research conducted within the copular framework. On the contrary, much of the empirical and descriptive work on so-called copular sentences remains valuable and can be seamlessly re-integrated into the present account as analyses of the $IN(A, B)$ component — that is, as investigations into how the domain of existence is specified. In this sense, the present analysis should be seen not as a wholesale rejection of the copular tradition, but as a theoretical expansion that situates its insights within a more comprehensive model of Japanese predication structure. Moreover, the interaction between the existence-asserting component $E(A)$ and the domain-specifying component $IN(A, B)$, which has received little explicit attention in previous research, may provide a potentially useful perspective for future studies on how these two semantic components relate to one another in information structure, negation and discourse.

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